

How to push back on a client without losing them

Push back calmly, early, and from the quote. Absorbing the cost teaches the client that your terms bend when they lean, and that lesson carries into the next job. Draw the line before any work happens, in three or four plain sentences with no apology, ending on a choice the client makes.

Why does pushing back feel like it will cost you the client?

Pushing back feels risky because the fear underneath it is always the same: if I push back, they'll leave. So the reflex is to absorb the extra work, the late invoice or the moved date, and keep the peace.

It's one of the things owners bring to me most often. Scope creep, an overrun, a dispute over what was agreed, a client who wants more for the same money. It arrives as a request for the right email. What the owner needs to hear first is that they aren't in a weak position, and that drawing a line doesn't end the relationship.

Absorbing the cost keeps the peace on the day. Meanwhile the resentment builds on your side, and the boundary appears all at once, late and in anger. A line held calmly and early reads as reassurance to a client. The client in the worked example below heard a line drawn late as an ambush.

How to draw a line calmly: the method, step by step

The method for drawing a line calmly is five steps: pause, find what was agreed, decide the choice before you write, write it short, and get the answer in writing before any work starts. The same five steps sit under every script in the next section.

1. **Pause before you reply.** The email lands and you feel the pull to apologise or to fire back. Wait, and use the pause rule below.

Copy and paste: the pause rule

Don't reply until you've opened the quote, found what was agreed, and can write the answer without an apology or an edge.

2. **Find what was agreed.** Check the quote for the thing being asked about: the deliverables, the date, the payment terms, the number of rounds. Everything you say next points at that page. If the quote doesn't cover it, settle this one with the choice in step 3, then put the terms on every quote from now on with the scope line in **the scope checklist**.
3. **Decide the choice before you write.** Every reply ends with the client picking between two options, and you decide them first. For extra work: pay for it, or keep to the scope. For a moved date: the new date with the real cost the move adds, or the original date as quoted. A lower rate is never one of the options. As the scope guide puts it, **"Scope flexes, the rate doesn't."**
4. **Write it in three or four sentences.** Acknowledge the request in a few words, state the fact from the quote, give the choice, and ask which they'd prefer. Leave out the apology, the paragraph of justification and the "I hope that's okay".
5. **Get the answer in writing before the work.** Whatever they choose, confirm it in one line, then do the work. If they push again, put the same choice back in front of them once.

What to say in five common pushback situations

Five common pushback situations are extra work outside the scope, late payment, a deadline the client moved, a fee cut after delivery, and footage the client wants that wasn't agreed. Each script below is three or four sentences, carries no apology, and ends on a choice or a next step. A note on asking for credit follows them.

When the client asks for extra work outside the scope

Extra work outside the scope is a variation: say yes, give the price, and get it agreed before you start.

Copy and paste: extra work outside the scope

Happy to do [the extra]. It sits outside what we scoped, so it's a variation at \$[Y]. Reply to confirm and I'll schedule it for [date], or we carry on as scoped and deliver on [date].

The on-site version, and the scope line that makes this easy, are in [the scope checklist](#). If the extra is another round of changes, use [the revision rounds guide](#), which has its own wording for that moment.

When the client pays late

A late payment gets a reply that points at the payment terms on the quote and asks for a date. Send it as soon as the invoice is overdue.

Copy and paste: a late payment

Hi [name], invoice [number] for [job] was due on [date] under the payment terms on the quote, and it's still open. Can you confirm the date it'll be paid? If something's holding it up on your side, tell me and we'll agree a date this week.

[Getting paid on time is part of the job you priced](#), so the reply doesn't need to explain why you'd like the money.

When the client moves the deadline

A moved deadline carries a price only when the move adds a real cost: a rush that needs extra crew or edit time, or a rebooking that costs you money. If the move costs you nothing, agree the new date.

Copy and paste: a moved deadline

No problem, we can work to [new date]. The change means [extra crew or edit time to meet it / the cost of rebooking (crew, venue)], which is \$[Y]. If you'd rather avoid that cost, we keep to [original date] as quoted. Which would you prefer?

When the client wants to cut the fee after delivery

A fee cut after delivery is a discount on work already done, so the reply separates a fault you'll fix from a price you'll hold. If something you delivered doesn't match what was agreed, you fix it at no cost. If the work matches, the invoice stands.

Copy and paste: a fee cut after delivery

I understand. The fee was agreed on the quote before we started, and the work was delivered to that scope, so the invoice stands at \$[X]. If anything we delivered doesn't match what we agreed, tell me what it is and I'll fix it at no cost. Otherwise the balance is due on [date].

The revision rounds guide puts the distinction in one line: "My mistake is free, your change of mind is paid."

When the client asks for raw footage or a new cut that wasn't agreed

Raw footage or a new cut from the same footage, beyond the agreed deliverables, is extra scope and gets priced like any other extra.

Copy and paste: raw footage or a new cut that wasn't agreed

Happy to. [The raw files / a new cut for (purpose)] wasn't part of what we scoped, so it's priced separately at \$[Y]. Reply to confirm and I'll [send the files / start the cut] by [date].

What about asking for credit or the right to show the work?

Credit and the right to show the work in your own marketing are fair things to want, as long as you ask once, lightly, with permission, and never make either a condition of the job. Getting paid is the credit that matters, so the scope, the payment terms and the client relationship come first.

A worked example

The worked example is one real job, anonymised, that shows what the line costs when it's drawn late. Edit only, four videos for a client of five years, two rounds of revisions quoted on each.

Two of the videos went through three rounds and one went through four, all absorbed. Six weeks in, another list of changes arrived, and the owner finally said the extra rounds would be charged: about \$300. The client felt ambushed, offered half, and told him to take it or leave it. The relationship ended, and by his own admission the job made no money.

	What happened	The line drawn calmly, early
When the line appeared	Week six, after at least four free rounds	Week one, on the quote
How the client heard the cost	On an invoice, after the work	Before each extra round, as a choice
The tone of the conversation	A dispute, and an offer of half	A routine question with two answers

He read it as a pricing problem. It was a boundary problem, missing since week one, and he tried to put it in place with a single email. The full story is in [the case study](#), and the method for rounds is in [the revision rounds guide](#).

The mistakes that undo it

Pushing back goes wrong in four predictable ways, and most of them come down to timing or tone.

- **Replying in the minute the email lands.** A reply written straight away is written by the fear or the irritation. Use the pause rule.
- **Apologising for your own terms.** "Sorry, but" tells the client the line is negotiable before they've pushed on it.
- **Saying no instead of giving a price.** A flat no turns the email into an argument. Give a price, or a choice between two options.
- **Waiting until you're resentful.** Every free round and every unchased invoice makes the eventual line harder to draw. In the worked example, at least four free rounds came before the first mention of money.

The rule of thumb for pushing back on a client

If it costs you time or money and it isn't on the quote, the client decides whether to pay for it before you do it.

The benchmark: every extra, rush or change on your last job was agreed in writing, with its price, before the work started.

Hold yourself accountable

Which of these have you taken on or put in place recently?

- The five scripts are saved where you write client emails, with your own figures in the brackets.
- The last time a client asked for something outside the scope, they got a price and a choice before you started.
- Your last overdue invoice was chased as soon as it was overdue, against the terms on the quote.
- The last time you felt the urge to fire off a reply, you used the pause rule.

Your one move this week

What's the one thing you can commit to implementing this week? If you're not sure, start here.

Find the last email where you absorbed something: an extra, a late payment, a moved date, a request to knock the fee down. Write the reply you'd send now using the matching script, then save all five scripts as templates in your email, with your own figures filled in.

One thing executed every week creates 50 strategic moves a year.

Questions like these come up regularly on our weekly Elite Boardroom calls. If you'd like someone to hold you to account each week, and to learn from a group of peers who run video businesses too, [the Boardroom is for you](#).

Related tools and guides. [How to get paid for everything you deliver: the scope checklist](#), [How many revision rounds to include](#), [The three revision emails](#), [Drop the scope, not the price](#), [Case study: the missing boundary](#), [Charging for the invisible work](#), [How to price a video project](#).



The field guides show you how the system works. The Boardroom is where I look at your business with you, give you perspective and judgement on what to do next, and hold you to it every week.

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